



DESKTOP PCs

More often than not, buying a new PC brings up the dilemma of whether you should opt for a slightly expensive branded system or settle for the local assembled PC. However, branded players are trying their best to break out of the stranglehold of assembled PCs by offering PCs priced below Rs 25,000.

The Premium PC from Zenith was truly a performance PC based on high performance hardware. It delivered on all counts.

The Zenith PC offers the Pentium 4 3.2 GHz. The processor supports hyper-threading and an awesome 800 MHz FSB. In the processor sub-system tests, the Pentium 4 3.2 GHz crushed all the records to come out tops. Even the motherboard used was top-notch—Intel's 865GBF. In addition, the system has 512 MB of DDR 400 MHz memory modules configured in dual-channel mode.

This PC comes with an Asus GeForce4 MX 440-8X card, which is DirectX 8.1 compliant—we were able to play Quake III at lower resolutions easily. It even opened a 200 MB TIFF file from the hard disk in

Zenith Premium PC

+ 3.2 GHz, 17-inch LCD
– No Operating System
Price: Rs 60,000
Contact: Zenith Computers Ltd
Phone: 022-2837 7300
Fax: 022-2837 7297
E-mail: one-up@zenith-india.com
Reviewed in: November 2003



PREVIOUS WINNERS

2002: Visualan Lavish
2001: Dell Dimension 8100

just half the time taken by the HCL Beanstalk 4658.

The Zenith PC stood out from rest of the crowd with its crisp, extremely good-looking 17-inch LCD Monitor. However, this machine didn't have either a combo drive, headphones, or a 56k PCI modem.

WORTHY MENTIONS

HCL Beanstalk 4658
+ Ennyah GeForce Fx-5200 graphics card, Microsoft Encarta bundled
– 256 MB RAM
Price: Rs 50,990
Contact: HCL Infosystems Ltd
Phone: 0120-252 0977
Fax: 0120-253 3877
E-mail: raman@hclinsys.com
Reviewed in: November 2003

HCL EzeeBee
+ Great value for money
– Needs a better graphics card
Price: Rs 27,490
Contact: HCL Infosystems Ltd
Phone: 0120-252 0977
Fax: 0120-253 3877
E-mail: raman@hclinsys.com
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There's no bundled OS or software, either.

However, in terms of pure performance, the Zenith PC beats the others by a significant margin.

DIGITAL CAMERAS

The Ixus 400 boasts of a four-megapixel CCD sensor with 3x optical zoom and 3.3x digital zoom, in an ultra compact body. The design is simple, clean and elegant. At the back, the camera cramps in a small, bright LCD, with all the necessary buttons near it. The CF slot and the USB connection are on the sides. An irritating rubber flap that covers the USB and AV-out jack mars the otherwise flawless design.

The Ixus 400 has perfect ergonomics. Since the buttons are placed beneath or near the LCD, there is enough space at the back to place your thumb in the natural position. This aids in single-handed camera usage. The lenses provide terrific zoom. The Ixus 400 also comes with shutter speeds ranging from as high as 15 seconds to as low as 1/2000th of a second. With five pre-defined flash modes and a host of metering techniques, you will never need a professional photographer for your wedding photographs. The camera comes with ISO speeds ranging from 50 to 400.

In the image test, the Ixus 400 came out

Canon Ixus 400

+ 4 megapixel, cerabrite body, five white balance modes
– Expensive
Price: Rs 49,995
Contact: Canon India Pvt Ltd
Phone: 011-2680 6572
Fax: 011-2680 7180
Email: shyam@canon.co.in
Reviewed In: September 2003



PREVIOUS WINNERS

2002: Olympus Camedia C-2100 Ultra Zoom
2001: Sony DSC-P1

tops, giving the best results of them all. It was able to pick up all three colours perfectly, and the deviation was within the acceptable 5-10 per cent range. The image was clear, bright and vibrant. In the specular and gradation test, the camera reproduced finer details with exemplary perfection. The camera blew the competition to bits in the RGB test.

WORTHY MENTIONS

Fuji Finepix S304
+ Good features, excellent performance, terrific price, 6x optical zoom
– Only 16 MB xD memory card, bulky
Price: Rs 34,000
Contact: Jindal Photo films Limited
Phone: 022-2850 4949
Fax: 022-2850 4044
Email: k_mohan/jpl@jindals.com
Reviewed In: September 2003

Kodak DX 6340
+ 4x optical zoom, 10 to 60 cm macro mode, supports SD/MMC card
– Built-in 16 MB memory
Price: Rs 20,900
Contact: Neoteric
Phone: 022-2417 2600
Fax: 022-2418 5294
Email: rajeev@neoteric-info.com
Reviewed In: September 2003

The camera costs Rs 50,000 in India, but is available for half that abroad, so you might want to think twice before buying it here.